OTTAWA, CANADA

National Gallery of Canada: Masterpieces

Twenty works at the National Gallery of Canada, considered through what they enlarge, surround or nearly hide.



A striped ship towers above its painters; a pine spreads across bands of water and sky. One is an industrial object altered for war, the other a landscape motif, yet both dominate through a strong structure that smaller details cannot undo. Placing them together offers a different starting point from treating a national collection as one continuous national style.

This selection from the National Gallery of Canada includes Canadian and international work, portraits as well as landscapes, and images that depart from recognisable objects. Its recurring question is one of scale: what is made large, what remains small, and where does the picture ask attention to settle? It is a partial selection, not a summary of the whole collection.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/national-gallery-canada

The selection · 20

1. The Jack Pine
   Tom Thomson · 1916–1917
2. The Death of General Wolfe
   Benjamin West · 1770
3. The Tangled Garden
   J. E. H. MacDonald · 1916
4. Hope I
   Gustav Klimt · 1903
5. Pavane
   Jean-Paul Riopelle · 1954
6. Dazzleships in Dry Dock at Liverpool
   Edward Wadsworth · 1919
7. A Canadian Gun-pit
   Wyndham Lewis · 1918
8. Port of Antwerp
   Georges Braque · 1906
9. North Sea I: Thunderstorm
   Max Beckmann · 1937
10. Solstice of the Sunflower
    Paul Nash · 1945
11. Portrait of a Man with a Felt Hat
    Lorenzo Lotto · 1541
12. Portrait of a Gentleman
    Bronzino · c. 1552
13. Anna Ivanovna Tolstaya
    Élisabeth Vigée Le Brun · 1796
14. Apple Trees in Bloom
    Alfred Sisley · 1880
15. September Afternoon, Eastern Townships
    John Arthur Fraser · 1873
16. A Shot in the Dawn, Lake Scugog
    John Arthur Fraser · 1873
17. At the Rogers Pass
    John Arthur Fraser · 1886
18. Edmond Dyonnet
    George Horne Russell · c. 1920
19. The Raven
    Odilon Redon · 1882
20. Oedipus Taken Down from the Tree
    Jean-François Millet · 1847

01 / 20

The Jack Pine

Tom Thomson

1916–1917 · National Gallery of Canada



Tom Thomson. The Jack Pine. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/tom-thomson/the-jack-pine-1917 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The pine's irregular branches cross a background organised in broad horizontal bands. Tree and distance therefore work differently: one interrupts, the other joins. The image's clarity comes from holding those structures together. Rather than losing its particular shape in a general idea of wilderness, this single tree becomes the means of organising an entire landscape.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

The Death of General Wolfe

Benjamin West

1770 · National Gallery of Canada



Benjamin West. The Death of General Wolfe. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The surrounding men direct their gestures and attention toward Wolfe's pale body. This arrangement turns a battlefield death into a scene of collective witnessing. The painting was made after the event and constructs its meaning; convincing uniforms and faces do not make it a literal record of the people present at one instant.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

The Tangled Garden

J. E. H. MacDonald

1916 · National Gallery of Canada



J. E. H. MacDonald. The Tangled Garden. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The drooping plants offer no single clear route through the garden. Leaves, flowers and bright patches overlap, requiring smaller acts of separation. MacDonald gives cultivated growth a density that exceeds easy tidiness. The picture rewards distinguishing neighbouring shapes without expecting the whole garden to resolve into a simple pattern.

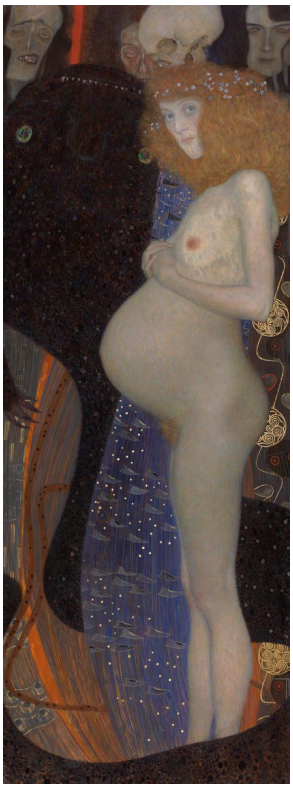
Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Hope I

Gustav Klimt

1903 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery of Canada



Gustav Klimt. Hope I. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/gustav-klimt/hope-i · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The pregnant figure is distinctly separated from the dark forms behind her. That contrast prevents the surrounding unease from making the body itself vague. The title's hope is consequently qualified by what accompanies it. Pregnancy and unsettling imagery share a field without settling into an uncomplicated celebration or a single fixed prediction.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Pavane

Jean-Paul Riopelle

1954 · National Gallery of Canada



Jean-Paul Riopelle. Pavane. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

No represented object tells the eye where to stop. Instead, the three sections and changing concentrations of colour provide different scales of organisation. Individual marks remain distinct within the extensive field. Repetition carries attention across the work, while differences in their density keep it from behaving like a uniformly repeated pattern.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Dazzleships in Dry Dock at Liverpool

Edward Wadsworth

1919 · National Gallery of Canada



Edward Wadsworth. Dazzle-ships in Drydock at Liverpool. Image credit: Edward Wadsworth; Source credit: Self-photographed by Mzajac of original painting.. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The striped hull towers over the people completing its paintwork. Dazzle camouflage was designed to confuse estimates of a ship's course, rather than simply make the vessel disappear. Wadsworth turns that deliberate optical disruption into a clearly organised picture, preserving both the geometric pattern and the enormous object to which it has been applied.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 8925

07 / 20

A Canadian Gun-pit

Wyndham Lewis

1918 · National Gallery of Canada



Wyndham Lewis. A Canadian Gun-pit. Image credit: Wyndham Lewis; Source credit: https://www.gallery.ca/collection/artwork/a-canadian-gun-pit. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The soldiers' tasks take their positions from the gun and its surrounding supports. Angular forms pass through bodies, equipment and ground, connecting people to the machinery they operate. The scene is still readable as work performed by individuals, but the weapon determines the shared space within which that work can happen.

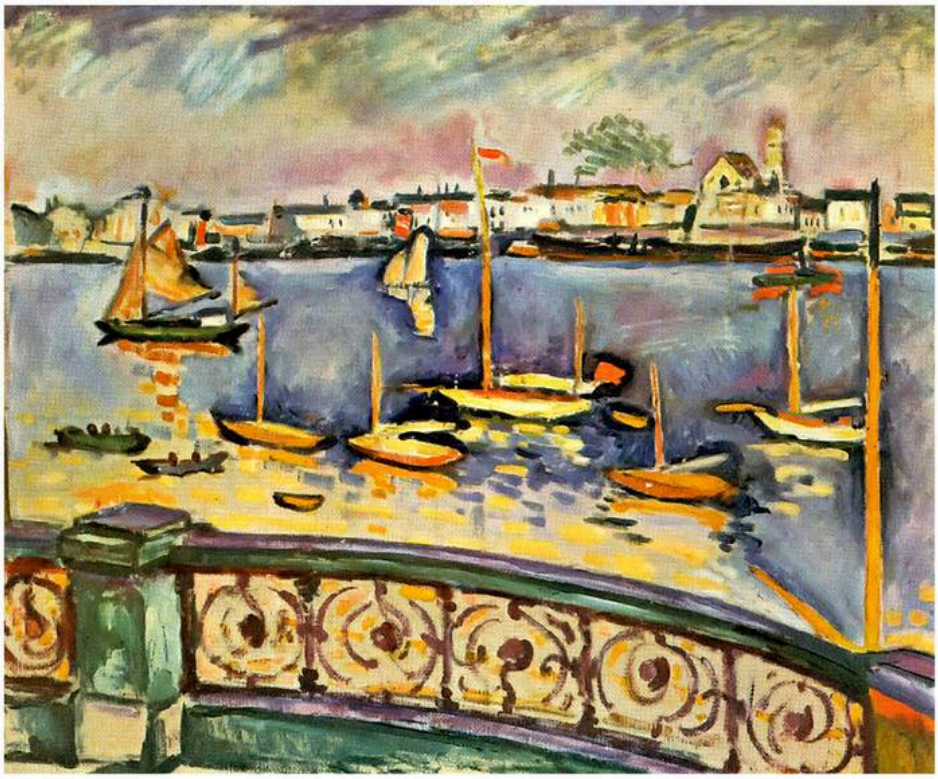
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 8356

08 / 20

Port of Antwerp

Georges Braque

1906 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery of Canada



Georges Braque. Port of Antwerp. WikiArt source label: Public domain US. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/georges-braque/port-of-antwerp-1906 · Public domain US (WikiArt source label)

The curved foreground railing gives the harbour a near boundary, while the boats and distant buildings occupy stronger fields of colour. Those colours do not have to match ordinary daylight to keep the place legible. The view's structure survives through relations between shapes, even as its hues depart from a restrained description of the waterfront.

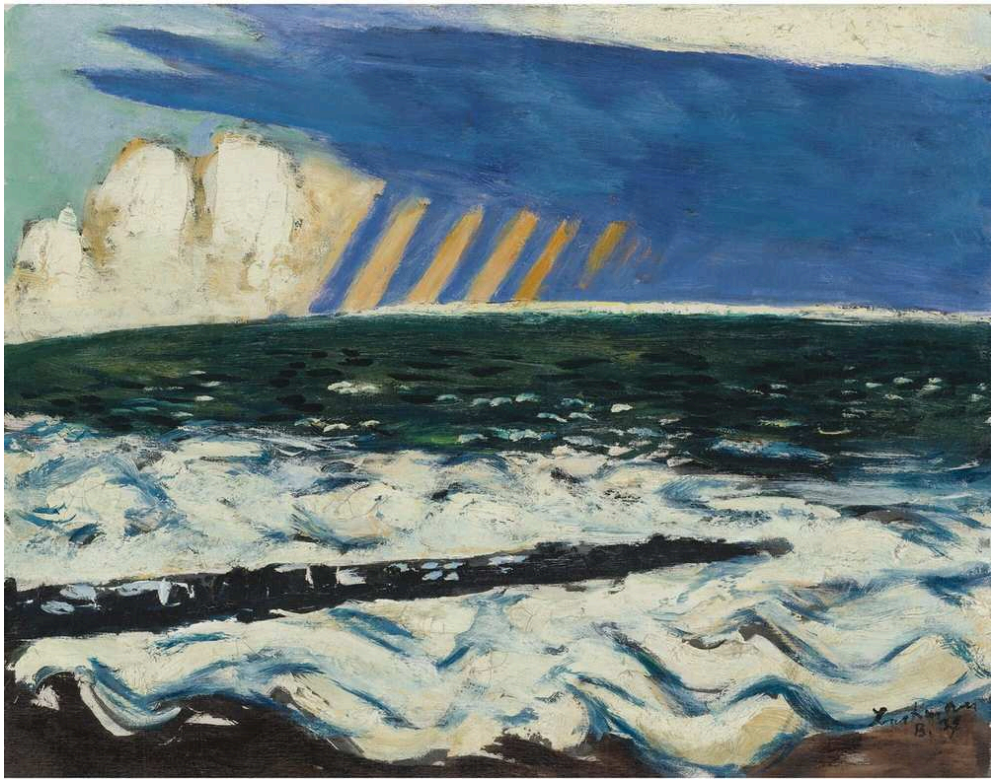
Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

North Sea I: Thunderstorm

Max Beckmann

1937 · National Gallery of Canada



Max Beckmann. North Sea I (Thunderstorm). Image credit: Max Beckmann; Source credit: https://www.sothebys.com/en/auctions/ecatalogue/2010/impressionist-modern-art-evening-sale-n08675/lot.57.html. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The narrow horizon leaves heavy sky pressing against broken water. Yellowish strokes descend through the clouds, introducing a direction that differs from the sea's rolling movement. Beckmann's emphatic divisions keep the storm structured and resistant. The weather does not dissolve the world into a soft, continuous haze.

Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

Solstice of the Sunflower

Paul Nash

1945 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery of Canada



Paul Nash. Solstice of the Sunflower. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/paul-nash/solstice-of-the-sunflower-1945 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The sunflower's enlarged head and the sun repeat a circular form at different positions in the landscape. Their resemblance organises the picture, but their scales cannot be reconciled as an ordinary view. Nash makes the connection available through painted invention, bringing plant and celestial body into a relationship that botanical accuracy alone would not produce.

Object source · Open artwork

11 / 20

Portrait of a Man with a Felt Hat

Lorenzo Lotto

1541 · Oil on paper · National Gallery of Canada



Lorenzo Lotto. Portrait of a Man with a Felt Hat. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/lorenzo-lotto/portrait-of-a-man-with-a-felt-hat-1541 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The held hat gives one hand a task while the direct gaze establishes another kind of contact. Broad dark clothing frames the face without an elaborate setting to explain the sitter's position. The object participates in the pose rather than merely accompanying it: removing it would change how the body presents itself.

Object source · Open artwork

12 / 20

Portrait of a Gentleman

Bronzino

c. 1552 · Oil on wood · National Gallery of Canada



Bronzino. Portrait of a gentleman. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/agnolo-bronzino/portrait-of-a-gentleman · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The small sculpture introduces a second kind of figure beside the living sitter. It connects the portrait to possessions and cultivated display, although it cannot by itself tell us everything the man knew or valued. Bronzino uses that juxtaposition to make social presentation part of the likeness rather than leaving the face to carry it alone.

Object source · Open artwork

13 / 20

Anna Ivanovna Tolstaya

Élisabeth Vigée Le Brun

1796 · National Gallery of Canada



Élisabeth Vigée Le Brun. Anna Ivanovna Tolstaya. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The resting head and loose drape suggest informality, yet both belong to a carefully arranged pose. Rocks and trees provide an alternative to an official interior without removing the portrait's control of appearance. The apparent ease is something constructed through the relation between dress, gesture and setting, not proof of an unguarded moment.

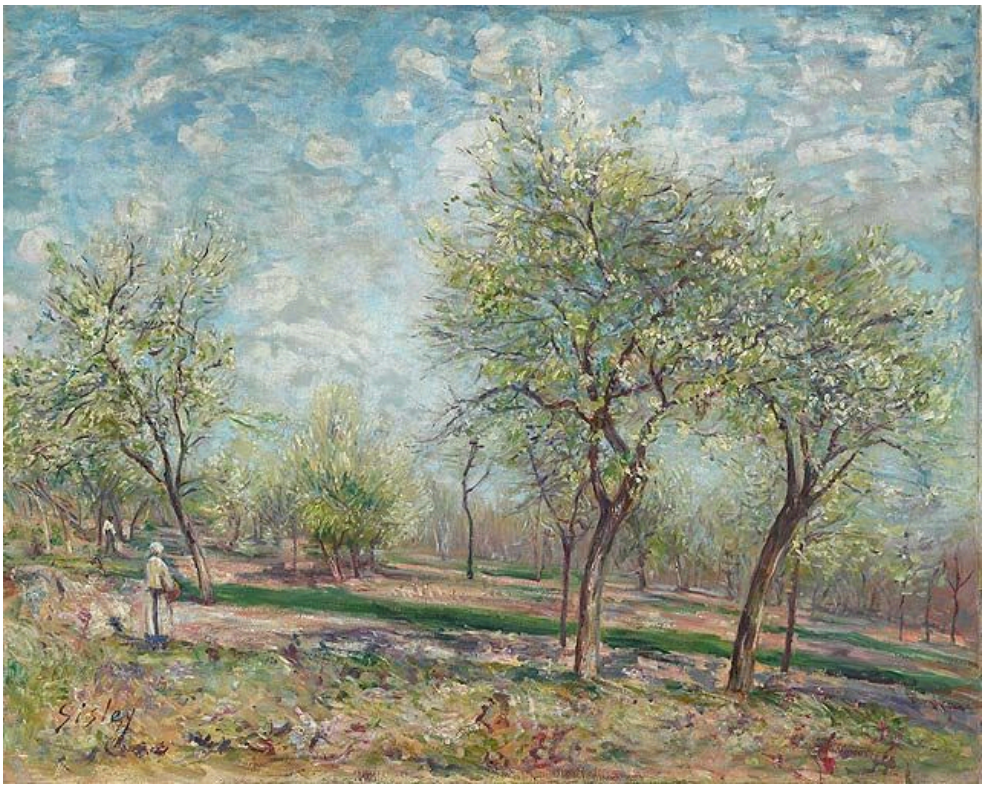
Object source · Open artwork

14 / 20

Apple Trees in Bloom

Alfred Sisley

1880 · National Gallery of Canada



Alfred Sisley. Apple Trees in Bloom. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The trunks establish repeated positions across the orchard, while blossoms break their outlines into lighter, less settled areas. No single tree needs to dominate. Depth comes from intervals between them and from small differences in colour, allowing the painting to retain a coherent space without a conspicuous central event.

Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

September Afternoon, Eastern Townships

John Arthur Fraser

1873 · National Gallery of Canada



John Arthur Fraser. September Afternoon, Eastern Townships. Image credit: John Arthur Fraser; Source credit: The AMICA Library. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The resting sheep give the near shore an inhabited scale. Beyond them, water and mountains extend through paler distances, so the view can be followed from small rural particulars to a much broader terrain. The flock matters partly because it does not take over: it supplies a measure for space that exceeds it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 18159

16 / 20

A Shot in the Dawn, Lake Scugog

John Arthur Fraser

1873 · National Gallery of Canada



John Arthur Fraser. A Shot in the Dawn, Lake Scugog. Image credit: John Arthur Fraser; Source credit: The AMICA Library. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The figure and dog are small beside the water and wide dawn sky. Without the title, their activity might remain secondary to the changes of light. Naming a shot redirects attention toward an event within the landscape, making a useful distinction between what occupies the most painted space and what words identify as the subject.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 6938

17 / 20

At the Rogers Pass

John Arthur Fraser

1886 · National Gallery of Canada



John Arthur Fraser. At the Rogers Pass, Summit of the Selkirk Range, B.C.. Image credit: John Arthur Fraser; Source credit: 1. The AMICA Library 2. Musée des beaux-arts du Canada, Ottawa. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Dark conifers establish the near valley before the eye reaches exposed, sunlit mountains. The movement between these bands gives scale without a large foreground person. Fraser makes the peaks seem distant through the ground that must be visually crossed to reach them, rather than relying on their outline alone.

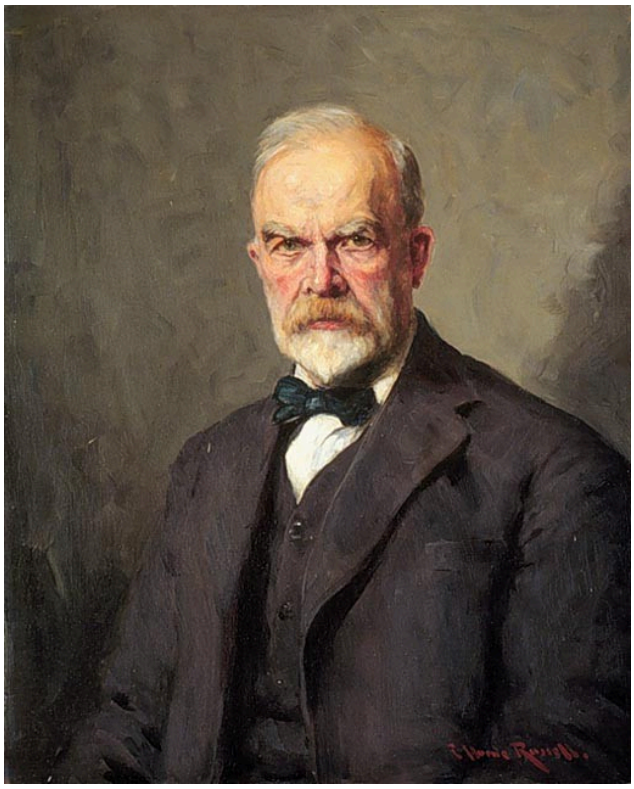
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 4227

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Edmond Dyonnet

George Horne Russell

c. 1920 · National Gallery of Canada



George Horne Russell. Edmond Dyonnet. Image credit: George Horne Russell; Source credit: Cybermuse des beaux arts du Canada. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The dark clothing and restrained ground leave the face and collar as the chief areas of light. Small tonal changes have to distinguish the features because few objects offer supplementary information about the sitter. This economy differs from Bronzino's portrait with a sculpture: identity is presented here with much less surrounding display.

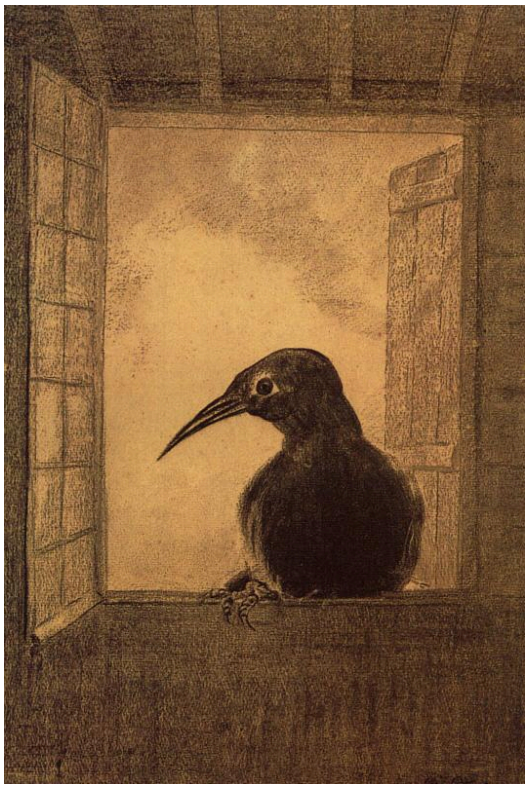
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 17947

19 / 20

The Raven

Odilon Redon

1882 · National Gallery of Canada



Odilon Redon. The Raven. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/odilon-redon/the-raven-1882 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The dark bird occupies a confined interior near an open window. Its head and beak remain distinct, concentrating attention on a small, watchful presence. The title carries a literary association, but the image does not need to illustrate an entire story. Enclosure and the bird's position supply a more limited, sustained situation.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Oedipus Taken Down from the Tree

Jean-François Millet

1847 · National Gallery of Canada



Jean-François Millet. Oedipus Taken Down from the Tree. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

A small child's exposed body becomes the point around which the figures gather. Dark branches enclose the group while light clarifies the act of handling and supporting that vulnerable weight. Millet makes the ancient subject intelligible through bodily relations before every detail of the Oedipus story has been identified.

Object source · Open artwork

What a small reproduction cannot measure

Compare these works in Artline, but keep their recorded dimensions nearby: a screen can make a small portrait and a large triptych seem equivalent. For an in-person visit, confirm availability with the gallery. Ownership and a catalogue entry do not necessarily mean a work is currently hanging.

Further reading

The Elements of Drawing

John Ruskin · Read free · English

Ruskin’s exercises in observing natural forms provide a useful starting point for Thomson, MacDonald and the landscape paintings. Read his judgments critically beside later artists who simplify or rearrange those forms instead of describing them continuously.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12